I looked at the flight commander, engaged the rotors and said, ‘Let’s get airborne, Sir.’

The ATC kept asking me to disengage and wait. I kept telling them that we would only get airborne and wait for the sanitization report before entering the combat zone. Technically, we weren’t breaking any rules, only bending them a little. But this would save us time. At least my flight commander was convinced. Soon, we were in the air and headed towards Kargil. As luck would have it, the ATC informed us before we entered the combat zone that the sanitization report had reached them and that we could go ahead. The flight commander looked at me, and we both smiled as our helicopter headed towards its mission.

The recce sortie was carried out and we were able to return to the Srinagar airstrip on time. Our damage-assessment report was submitted to the higher headquarters. The dull start to the day had ended with an adrenaline rush. The takeaway was that things could change in war in no time. Orders could come anytime from anywhere, and they had to be followed. The mission was the priority, and with a little ingenuity, one could accomplish the mission against all odds. But rules had to be followed even during the hardest times. Procedures that were set in place over years of experience had a purpose and they should never be bypassed. Discipline was the key to soldiering.

I cannot say for sure how much our report helped the higher headquarters but such small reports from all departments must have helped in getting a glimpse of the bigger picture. The air force was playing its role so well that on 12 June 1999, the Pakistani foreign minister Sartaj Aziz hastily arrived in New Delhi and implored India to stop the air strikes. Finally, in the next two days, after a coordinated effort by the air force and the army, the difficult posts on the icy slopes of Tololing were captured. Tololing was won on 13 June 1999. It changed the course of the war thereafter.